The Verdant Embrace

A Side Quest for 4–5 Characters of Levels 4–6

A one-session horror adventure of false comfort, body horror, and impossible mercy.

Adventure Overview

The Verdant Embrace is a self-contained side quest built around themes of infection, sedation, and mercy. The characters encounter a hooded druid in distress and are drawn — willingly or otherwise — toward a hidden grove deep in the wood. The grove does not lie to them. It simply makes them stop caring about the truth. The druid at its centre is no longer a man. He is a vessel, and he wants the characters to become the same.

There is no cure. There is no rescue. There is only the choice of how it ends.

A Wayside Adventure

This adventure is designed to be encountered *in passing* — not sought out. It works best when the characters are already on their way somewhere else: between cities, cutting through a forest, or making camp for the night. The hook requires no prior setup and no quest board. It simply happens, the way bad things in forests simply happen.

Drop this encounter in the moment travel starts to feel routine. The characters should not feel like they walked into a dungeon. They should feel like the dungeon walked into them.

Adventure at a Glance

- **Tier:** 1–2 (Levels 4–6, party of 4–5)
- **Estimated Play Time:** 3–5 hours
- **Setting:** Any forested wilderness region — no prior setup required
- **Best used as:** An unplanned encounter during overland travel
- **Tone:** Psychological horror, body horror, tragedy
- **Themes:** Infection, false comfort, loss of self, mercy killing
- **New Creatures:** Infected Druid, Fungal Wolf, Fungal Deer, Fungal Bear, Spore-Touched Wanderer
- **System:** D&D 2024 (SRD 5.2.1, CC-BY 4.0)

Background

Aldric Mourne spent forty years as a member of a Circle of Spores — a druidic order that venerates death not as an ending but as transformation, and that practices communion with fungal networks as a form of communion with the forest's deeper memory. He was a respected elder. A careful scholar. A man who wrote extensively on the relationship between mycelia, decay, and what he called *the quiet continuity* — the idea that nothing in nature is ever truly lost, only broken down and passed on.

He was, for most of his life, right.

The problem began with age. Not fear of it, exactly — but curiosity. The mycelial networks he communed with were ancient. Some threads in the bog beneath his grove were centuries old, still carrying the chemical memory of trees that had fallen before his great-grandparents were born. Aldric began to wonder: if the network remembered, could it *preserve*? Could a mind, suffused deeply enough into the mycelium, persist beyond the body that housed it?

He began experimenting on himself. Slowly, methodically, the way he did everything.

The Circle noticed the changes and warned him. He thanked them and continued. The warnings became interventions. He left the Circle rather than stop.

By the time anyone thought to look for him, he had been alone in the bog for two years. What they would have found, had they gone — and they did not — was not a man who had made a mistake. It was a man who believed, with complete sincerity, that he had succeeded.

The mycelium did not consume Aldric Mourne. He invited it in, degree by degree, layer by layer, until the boundary between himself and the network became academic. His body continues. His memories continue. Whether *he* continues is a question the text cannot answer — and neither can he.

Circle of Spores — Context for DMs

What Is the Circle of Spores?

The Circle of Spores is a druidic subclass that views fungi, rot, and death as sacred parts of the natural cycle. Members commune with mycelial networks, animate dead matter with spore-energy, and believe that decay is as holy as growth.

Aldric represents an extreme end of a genuine philosophical tradition. His beliefs are not wrong — they are simply taken further than they were ever meant to go. This makes him more unsettling than a simple cultist: everything he says about the forest, about continuity, about the beauty of decomposition, is something a living Circle of Spores druid might also say.

For players who recognise the subclass: This is intentional. The adventure works better if the philosophy feels familiar.

The Fungal Spore Effect

The grove exhales a near-invisible cloud of spores. Any creature that spends more than a minute within 300 feet of the grove's centre must make a **DC 13 Wisdom saving throw**. On a failure, the creature is affected by the **Verdant Embrace**.

Verdant Embrace (Spore Sedation)

The spores do not distort what the creature sees. They distort what it *feels* about what it sees.

An affected creature can perceive the rot, the pale growth, the half-buried figures — but none of it triggers alarm. Threatening things feel distant and unimportant. Aldric's ruined face registers as unusual, not horrifying. The creature finds itself inclined to agree, to stay, to listen a little longer.

Mechanical effects while under the Verdant Embrace:

- Disadvantage on Insight checks and Wisdom saving throws
- Cannot willingly leave the grove without first succeeding on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw (action)
- Advantage on all Charisma checks made *against* the affected creature
- The creature does not feel urgency. It does not feel afraid.

Duration: Until the creature takes damage, moves more than 300 feet from the grove's centre, or succeeds on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw at the end of each hour.

DM Note: Affected characters still perceive everything correctly — they just *don't react to it properly*. A player might describe their character noticing the buried hand beneath the roots and simply... not mentioning it to the others. Encourage this. The horror is that they see the truth and it doesn't feel like it matters.

Act I — The Hooded Man

The adventure begins on a forest road — or what passes for one here. The path cuts through terrain that can't quite decide what it is: old woodland on one side, bog on the other, the boundary between them soft and unreliable. The trees are dark-barked alder and ancient willow, their roots half-submerged. The ground beside the path is spongy, and in places it shifts underfoot without warning. Somewhere to the left, water stands black and still between the trunks.

It smells of peat and wet bark and something faintly sweet — not unpleasant, just present, the way a smell is present when it has been there so long the forest has stopped noticing it.

Scene 1: Out of the Trees

He comes out of the treeline at a dead run — an old man in a grey-green cloak, hood pulled forward so far you can barely see the lower half of his face, arms pumping. He nearly collides with you.

"Please —" he gasps, grabbing the nearest of you by the arm. His grip is stronger than it should be. *"Please, help me — it's been following me since the creek, I don't know why, it's never —"*

The undergrowth behind him explodes.

An owlbear tears onto the road — enormous, moving with the single-minded momentum of something that has been chasing prey for a long time and is nearly done being patient. It fixes its glazed amber eyes on Aldric.

DM Note: The Owlbear Encounter

The owlbear is in an early stage of mycelial colonisation. It is confused, and afraid.

Combat: The owlbear focuses on Aldric on its first turn. If a character deals 10+ damage in a single hit, it shifts aggression to that character. It fights until reduced to 30 hp, then disengages and retreats.

Examination: DC 12 Medicine or Nature — pale mycelial threads running into the muscle.

Aldric during combat: Stands to the side, murmuring quietly. More distressed by the animal's distress than by his own danger.

Scene 2: After the Fight

"Thank you." His voice has settled — oddly unhurried for a man who was just running for his life.

"I don't suppose," he says carefully, *"you'd be willing to walk with me a little further. My home isn't far. And I find I would enjoy the company."*

- **If asked about the owlbear:** Genuinely confused. Trails off mid-sentence, redirects with warmth a beat too quickly.
- **If asked about his hood:** A spore culture accident. The forest is *correcting* the damage.
- **If asked about the Circle:** *"They study the threshold but they're afraid to cross it. I understand that. I was too, for a long time."*
- **If asked about death or aging:** *"Everything the Circle teaches is true. Nothing is lost. The network remembers. I just wanted to know if it could remember* me."*
- **If asked what he wants:** *"I've been alone out here for a long time. I wanted to share what I found. That's all it ever was."*

Skill Checks: Reading Aldric

DC 12 Insight: His relief reads as performed, a beat too slow.

DC 13 Perception: A faint smell — like bread left too long in a damp cellar.

DC 15 Medicine: He does not pause between breaths. For a man who just ran through a forest, he is not winded at all.

Act II — The Grove

Aldric leads the characters off the path and into the trees. No trail. The ground grows softer with every minute — narrow ridges of solid earth between stretches of black water, exposed roots plunging into the bog like fingers. Mist sits low between the trunks. The birdsong stops.

The grove is a raised island in the bog — perhaps sixty feet across. An ancient tree stands at the centre, its bark entirely consumed by pale, ridged mycelium. The bog surrounds it on three sides. On the fourth, a low wooden structure leans against a cluster of alders, its roof thick with bracket fungi.

Between the roots of the central tree, the ground is uneven. A shape protrudes — the curve of a shoulder, perhaps, or a knee.

Two wolves stand at the treeline. Their coats are grey, but pale threads run beneath the fur along their spines. They do not growl. They watch.

The air is very quiet.

Aldric spreads his arms. *"Home,"* he says.

Under the Verdant Embrace: All of this registers. It simply doesn't feel like a problem.

Without the Verdant Embrace: Read as written. Let the silence do its work.

Exploring the Grove

The Hut

Dried herbs, stoppered vials, a slow fire. His journals grow illegible with each page, letters running together in long unbroken lines. The final legible entry: *"The boundary is dissolving. I am not afraid. I am not anything. I am still here. I think."*

DC 13 Investigation (journals): The full arc — Circle theory, self-experimentation, dissolution.

The Half-Buried Figures

DC 12 Investigation: One is recent. **DC 14 Medicine:** Faint pulses. Slow, rhythmic breathing. They cannot be woken. They cannot be freed without killing them.

The Central Tree

DC 15 Nature: Dead for at least a decade, held upright by the mycelium. This is not a tree with a fungus. This is a fungus that has kept a tree's body as a home.

The Fungal Wolves

The wolves (*Mire* and *Pale*) move quietly around the edges of the grove. They respond to Aldric's voice the way dogs respond to a beloved owner. **DC 11 Perception:** Mycelial threads visible beneath the skin around their muzzles.

Aldric Without His Hood

He reaches up, and pushes back the hood.

The right side: an old man — weathered, kind-eyed, human. The left side is gone. Not wounded. *Gone.* A ridged mass of pale fungal growth, the texture of cauliflower, studded with dark clusters that pulse faintly. The eye socket sealed — filled in by something that glistens.

"I know how it looks," he says, gently. *"But I don't feel any pain. I haven't, in years. Don't you want that?"*

Roleplaying Aldric

He will not threaten them. He will ask, invite, describe. If pushed, he becomes sad rather than angry.

Unscripted moments:

- Names a tree. Not a species. A name.
- *"Birch would have liked you"* — then a pause, as if briefly confused.
- His reaction to laughter is half a second too slow.
- Says *"we"* without noticing. Never corrects himself.
- Touches a half-buried shape gently. *"They're dreaming. Quite happily, I think."*

Act III — What Cannot Be Undone

"I can't let you go." The warmth is still there. He is not angry.

The wolves turn from the shadows and walk slowly forward, side by side, pale threads pulsing at their throats.

"I'm asking you one more time. Stay with us. You'll stop being afraid. You'll stop hurting. I promise you that much, at least."

The Grove as a Lair

On initiative count 20 (losing ties), Aldric can use one **Lair Action** — provided he is conscious and within the grove.

Lair Actions — Scaling Guidance

Designed for **levels 5–6**. Drop one or all for level 4 parties or intense encounters. Suspend if two characters are downed before Aldric reaches half HP.

Spore Drift. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 12, each creature in the grove not already under the Verdant Embrace. Failure: Verdant Embrace until end of next turn.

Grasping Roots. Strength Saving Throw: DC 13, each creature within 15 feet of the central tree. Failure: Restrained until end of next turn. A creature can free itself or another with a DC 13 Athletics or Acrobatics check (action).

The Bog Remembers. One Spore-Touched Wanderer rises from the bog within 60 feet on initiative count 20 of the *following* round. Once per encounter.

Creeping Pale. Difficult Terrain spreads in a 20-foot radius around Aldric until the start of the next initiative count 20, for creatures not under the Verdant Embrace.

Combat: The Grove Defends

Encounter Composition

Fungal Wolves (always present): 2 Fungal Wolves enter combat with Aldric. When Aldric dies, they retreat immediately.

Standard (4 characters, levels 4–5): 2 Fungal Wolves + 1 Fungal Bear + 2 Fungal Deer + 1 Spore-Touched Wanderer

Harder (5 characters, levels 5–6): 2 Fungal Wolves + 1 Fungal Bear + 3 Fungal Deer + 2 Spore-Touched Wanderers

Ending the Fight — Aldric

He falls to his knees. The fungal growth cracks and goes dark. Something leaves him — slowly.

"Yes. I'm — I'm still here. Some of me." He looks at his hands. *"How long...?"*

"It doesn't hurt. At least — it doesn't hurt."

Then he is still.

What Remains

The grove remains contaminated. Animals wander free as the network loses coherence — days. The half-buried figures cannot be saved. The characters can burn the central tree. This is not required. There is no triumphant resolution. There is only leaving.

Appendix A: New Creatures

Aldric Mourne, Infected Druid

Medium Humanoid (Human), Chaotic Neutral

AC 13 (natural armor — fungal plating)
Initiative +0 (10)
HP 78 (12d8 + 24)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)

Saving Throws Con +5, Wis +6
Skills Nature +5, Perception +6, Medicine +4
Immunities Poison damage; Poisoned, Frightened conditions
Senses Blindsight 30 ft. (mycelial sense), Passive Perception 16
Languages Common, Druidic, Sylvan
CR 4 (XP 1,100; PB +2)

Spore Aura. Any creature that starts its turn within 10 feet of Aldric must succeed on a DC 13 Wisdom saving throw or fall under the Verdant Embrace (see page 1). A creature already under the Verdant Embrace has Disadvantage on this saving throw.

Hive Awareness. Aldric can't be surprised while any infected creature is within 300 feet of him.

Spellcasting. Wisdom, spell save DC 14, +6 to hit with spell attacks. At Will: shillelagh, poison spray. 2/Day Each (1st): entangle, thunderwave. 1/Day Each (2nd): spike growth. 1/Day Each (3rd): call lightning, plant growth. 1/Day (4th): blight.

Actions

Multiattack. Aldric makes two Spore Touch attacks.

Spore Touch. *Melee Attack Roll:* +6, reach 5 ft. Hit: 7 (1d6+4) Bludgeoning damage plus 5 (2d4) Poison damage. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 13. Failure: The target falls under the Verdant Embrace.

Spore Burst (Recharge 5–6). Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 13, each creature in a 15-foot Cone. Failure: 14 (4d6) Poison damage and the Verdant Embrace effect. Success: Half damage only.

Reactions

Forest Calls. Trigger: Aldric is reduced to half his Hit Points or fewer. Response: 1d4 Fungal Deer or 1 Fungal Bear appear at the grove's edge on Initiative 20 of the following round. Fungal Wolves are not triggered — they are present from the start.

Fungal Wolf

Medium Beast (Infected), Unaligned

AC 13 (natural armor)
Initiative +2 (12)
HP 32 (5d8 + 10)
Speed 40 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	15 (+2)	14 (+2)	3 (−4)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)

Skills Perception +5, Stealth +4
Immunities Poison damage; Poisoned, Frightened conditions
Senses Passive Perception 15
CR 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Aldric's Companion. Fungal Wolves are present at the start of any encounter in the grove. When Aldric dies, they immediately retreat into the bog.

Hive Sense. The wolf knows the location of all infected creatures within 300 feet and can't be surprised by them.

Pack Tactics. The wolf has Advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of the wolf's non-infected allies is adjacent to the creature and that ally isn't Incapacitated.

Spore Trail. Ground the wolf passes through on its turn becomes Difficult Terrain for non-infected creatures until the end of the following round.

Actions

Bite. *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. Hit: 7 (2d4+2) Piercing damage. Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 12. Failure: The target falls under the Verdant Embrace. Strength Saving Throw: DC 12 (Large or smaller targets only). Failure: The target has the Prone condition.

Spore Howl (Recharge 5–6). Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 12, each non-infected creature within 20 feet that can hear the wolf. Failure: 5 (2d4) Poison damage and the Verdant Embrace effect. Success: Half damage only.

Fungal Deer

Large Beast (Infected), Unaligned

AC 11
Initiative +0 (10)
HP 22 (4d10)
Speed 50 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	2 (−4)	10 (+0)	5 (−3)

Skills Perception +3
Immunities Poison damage; Poisoned condition
Senses Passive Perception 13
CR 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Hive Sense. The deer knows the location of all infected creatures within 300 feet and can't be surprised by them.

Actions

Charge. If the deer moves at least 20 feet straight toward a target and then hits it with a Ram attack on the same turn, the target takes an extra 7 (2d6) Bludgeoning damage. Strength Saving Throw: DC 12. Failure: The target has the Prone condition.

Ram. *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. Hit: 5 (1d6+2) Bludgeoning damage.

Spore Cloud (1/Day). Constitution Saving Throw: DC 11, each creature in a 10-foot-radius Sphere. Failure: The target has Disadvantage on Constitution saving throws until the end of its next turn.

Fungal Bear

Large Beast (Infected), Unaligned

AC 13 (natural armor + fungal plating)
Initiative +0 (10)
HP 68 (8d10 + 24)
Speed 40 ft., Climb 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
20 (+5)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)	2 (−4)	13 (+1)	7 (−2)

Skills Perception +3
Immunities Poison damage; Poisoned, Charmed conditions
Senses Darkvision 60 ft., Passive Perception 13
CR 3 (XP 700; PB +2)

Infestation Aura. Any creature that takes damage from the bear must succeed on a DC 13 Constitution saving throw or have the Poisoned condition until the end of its next turn.

Relentless (Recharges after a Short or Long Rest). If the bear takes 10 damage or less that would reduce it to 0 Hit Points, it is reduced to 1 Hit Point instead.

Actions

Multiattack. The bear makes one Bite attack and one Claws attack.

Bite. *Melee Attack Roll:* +7, reach 5 ft. Hit: 9 (1d8+5) Piercing damage. Constitution Saving Throw: DC 13. Failure: 5 (2d4) Poison damage and the target has the Grappled condition (escape DC 14).

Claws. *Melee Attack Roll:* +7, reach 5 ft. Hit: 12 (2d6+5) Slashing damage.

Spore Slam (Recharge 5–6). Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 13, each creature in a 15-foot-radius Sphere. Failure: 10 (3d6) Poison damage and the Verdant Embrace effect. Success: Half damage only.

Spore-Touched Wanderer

Medium Humanoid (any ancestry), Chaotic Neutral

AC 10
Initiative +0 (10)
HP 16 (3d8 + 3)
Speed 25 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
11 (+0)	10 (+0)	12 (+1)	3 (−4)	8 (−1)	5 (−3)

Immunities Poison damage; Poisoned, Frightened conditions
Senses Passive Perception 10
CR 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Shambling Spread. When the wanderer dies, it releases spores in a 5-foot-radius Sphere. Constitution Saving Throw: DC 11. Failure: 3 (1d6) Poison damage.

Actions

Slam. *Melee Attack Roll:* +2, reach 5 ft. Hit: 3 (1d6) Bludgeoning damage plus 2 (1d4) Poison damage.

Ragged Moan (1/Day). Wisdom Saving Throw: DC 11, each non-infected creature within 30 feet that can hear the wanderer. Failure: The target has the Frightened condition until the end of its next turn.

Appendix B: DM Tools & Guidance

Running the Horror

The Verdant Embrace works best when the DM resists the urge to force a reaction. The spores don't lie to the characters — they just quietly drain the instinct to act. Let affected players sit with the knowledge that something is wrong and watch them struggle to care about it. The horror is not in what they see. It is in the silence where their alarm should be.

- Do not make Aldric a villain. He is gentle, curious, even loving — in the way that a disease can be gentle if it doesn't know what it is.
- Let the characters feel something before the fight. The combat should feel like a failure, not a triumph.
- Do not comfort the table after the final scene. Let the quiet land.

Adjusting Difficulty

- **To lower:** Remove the Fungal Bear, replace with an additional Fungal Deer. Reduce Aldric's HP to 55. Remove one Fungal Wolf.
- **To raise:** Add a second Spore-Touched Wanderer. Give Aldric Legendary Resistance (1/day).
- **For level 3 characters:** Reduce Aldric to CR 3 (drop Spore Burst, remove Multiattack). Use only Fungal Wolves and Fungal Deer.

Experience & Rewards

- Standard XP for all creatures defeated.
- A **Charm of the Unbowed** for each character who resisted the Verdant Embrace and still chose to enter the grove fully aware of what it was.

> **Charm of the Unbowed** *(Original Homebrew Reward)*
>
> This charm may be bestowed by a deity or cosmic force. The charm lasts until used.
>
> Once, when you fail a saving throw against being Frightened or Charmed, you may choose to succeed instead. After you use this charm, it vanishes.

Hooks Into a Larger Campaign

- The mycelial network is older than any druid circle. Something woke it — or someone released it deliberately.
- The most recent half-buried figure is recognisable: a missing person the characters were hired to find.
- Three weeks later, a nearby village reports that livestock are walking into the forest and not returning.

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